



Judges vent ire at DOJ attorneys

Aggressive actions by administration are being criticized from the bench

BY MARK BERMAN AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

Justice Department lawyers defending the Trump administration's policies are encountering mounting criticism and frustration from federal judges, a sign of deepening tension between the executive branch and courts weighing its aggressive uses of power.

In recent hearings and rulings, judges appointed by presidents of both parties have criticized the statements and behavior of administration officials, accusing them of defying court orders, submitting flimsy evidence, providing inadequate answers to questions and even acting like toddlers.

The cases involve lawsuits challenging everything from President Donald Trump's push to increase deportations to his efforts to punish law firms. Most are in the early stages of litigation. But the judicial pushback suggests a break from the goodwill courts have traditionally shown toward assertions by government lawyers.

The "deference that judges would give to attorneys from Main Justice is evaporating," said John E. Jones III, a former federal judge in Pennsylvania appointed to the bench by President George W. Bush. Justice Department lawyers, he added, have "lost a fair measure of their credibility."

At a hearing in D.C. last week about law firms, U.S. District

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Interview: Trump: "I don't know" on need to uphold Constitution. A2

In a first, spinal tumor is removed through eye

BY MARK JOHNSON

Just before the medical staff wheeled Karla Flores into the operating room so that surgeons could work inside her head for the third time in less than a month, the 19-year-old budding manicurist said goodbye to her mom and dad. She didn't know if she would see them again.

Her previous surgeries in the same building at the University of Maryland Medical Center had been hard enough: a pair of 14-hour procedures to rid Flores's brain of a rare bone tumor the size of a chicken's egg. This time, the surgeons faced a greater challenge. A second, smaller chordoma was strangling Flores's spinal cord near the base of the skull. After much discussion, the medical team had decided to try something that had never been done.

They would remove the spinal tumor through her left eye socket.

If the surgical path was not precise to within a few millimeters, Flores could lose all movement below the neck or suffer a fatal brain-stem stroke. If the procedure was successful, however, it would open a new avenue for doctors around the world treating difficult-to-reach tumors.

SEE SURGERY ON A6



JOE BUGLEWICZ/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A worker prepares hand dryers for shipping at Excel Dryer. The company's all-domestic supply chain largely protects it from tariffs.

Mass. factory sees a boon in tariffs

Excel Dryer's experience also shows the difficulty of insulating supply chains from the levies

BY DAVID J. LYNCH

EAST LONGMEADOW, MASS. — Tariffs have clipped stock values, shrunk the dollar and slammed the U.S. economy into reverse.

But at the local Excel Dryer plant, William Gagnon, the chief operating officer, is unfazed. In fact, President Donald Trump's import taxes so far have been nothing but good news for one of the world's largest makers of restroom hand dryers.

Gagnon, 48, credits Trump's first-term tariffs with changing the math on production location decisions, enabling Excel to construct an all-domestic supply chain that insulates the company against the uncertainty roiling much of U.S. manufacturing and gives its an edge over

competitors that import their dryers.

With luck, the president's second-term "reciprocal" tariffs might result in the elimination of trade barriers that prevent Excel's high-velocity hand dryers from dominating markets in countries such as Brazil and Australia.

"We have good representation internationally, but we're really looking to grow that, and what we're finding is we have a lot of barriers to entry," Gagnon said. "The reciprocal tariff approach is really going to open up more international markets for us."

Many manufacturers share Gagnon's sentiments. But Excel's experience also

illustrates the difficulties involved in tariff-proofing supply chains, the limits of what tariffs can achieve and the obstacles that the president's domestic manufacturing push will face.

Just past the 100th day of his second White House term, Trump's tariffs are not popular. Companies across the United States complain that the president's shape-shifting import taxes make planning and investment all but impossible.

Americans reject the Trump levies by a margin of nearly 2 to 1, according to a recent Washington Post-ABC News-Ipsos national poll. Overall, 64 percent of adults surveyed — including 70 percent of political independents — said they

SEE TARIFFS ON A4

Jair Bolsonaro, brash and bereft

In interview, former Brazilian leader is a (mostly) defiant defendant pining for his hero — Trump

BY TERRENCE MCCOY AND MARINA DIAS

BRAZÍLIA — Jair Bolsonaro was surrounded by his own image. It graced most available surfaces at his party's headquarters, from the walls to the coffee mugs. There was a large painting of Bolsonaro wearing his presidential sash. Photos of Bolsonaro before thousands of supporters, arm reaching into the sky. A golden bust of Bolsonaro, grim-faced, placed before a painting of an even grimmer-faced Bolsonaro.

But none of these was the image that Bolsonaro wanted us to see.

Bolsonaro, awaiting trial before the Brazilian Supreme Court on accusations he plotted to assassinate his rivals and stay in power after his 2022 election loss, pulled over a thick coffee-table book written and given to him by President Donald Trump.

"I didn't pay anything," said the 70-year-old Bolsonaro, twice. "Look, he even signed it."

On Page 305, beside a letter Bolsonaro had written to Trump — "You'll always have a friend in Brazil" — he found a large photo of himself alongside Trump, and another on the next page. He lingered to admire the photos, reliving his political apex, his moment of greatest proximity to a figure he had long sought to emulate. Then he closed the book and returned to a present and very different mo-



DAN AGOSTINI/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Jair Bolsonaro is awaiting a trial related to an alleged coup plot.

ment:

Out of power. Unable to run for office until 2030. Facing the prospect of four decades in prison. Prohibited from leaving the country.

"I couldn't go to [Trump's] inauguration," he mourned. "My passport had been apprehended."

I've been reporting on Bolsonaro for six years, from his rise to power through the darkest days of Brazil's devastating coronavirus outbreak, from his electoral loss to the storming of the capital by thousands of supporters in protest of the result. But our interview last month was my first time sitting down with him. Walking into a conference room at the Liberal Party headquarters with Post reporter Marina Dias and photographer Dan Agostini, I expected to find the brash, aggressive Bolsonaro I'd come to know from his public persona.

The Bolsonaro who had mocked the coronavirus. Inflamed calls for a military takeover. Clashed with the Supreme Court. Alleged without evidence that the electoral system was rigged against him. And made a vulgar campaign slogan out of the Portuguese word "imbrochável" — something like "never flaccid" — to tout his supposed virility.

In many respects, we found that Bolsonaro. He was physically imposing, irreverent, charismatic,

SEE BOLSONARO ON A9

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THE REGION

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A landlord in the District was sentenced to nearly 36 years in prison over the 2019 deaths of two people in a fire at one of his properties. B1

A police helicopter search forced three airliners to change their landing plans at Reagan National Airport. B3

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In an upcoming exhibition, the Metropolitan Museum of Art celebrates Black male beauty, Robin Givhan writes. C1

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